

Antarctic hunters

Many of the penguins, seals, and other animals that feed in the rich waters around Antarctica are hunted by leopard seals and orcas—the most powerful predators in the Southern Ocean. Leopard seals are solitary ambush hunters, while orcas prowl the icy seas in hunting packs that work together to outwit and overpower their prey.



LEAP OF FAITH

Although there are no killer sharks in the icy seas around Antarctica, the water is patrolled by equally dangerous predators. The penguins and seals that spend much of their time on the floating sea ice know that every time they enter the water to find food, they risk death. For these Adélie penguins, a high-speed dive from an iceberg offers the best chance of avoiding attack, because they are moving so fast when they hit the water that their enemies have less time to seize them.

AMBUSH KILLER

The powerful leopard seal eats a lot of krill, but it also preys on penguins and other Antarctic seals—especially crabeater seals. Its favorite tactic is to lurk beneath the edge of the floating ice and wait for a victim to slip into the water. If it is a penguin, the leopard seal seizes it and thrashes it around in the water to kill it. This action also makes the penguin's skin and feathers peel away from its body, so the meal is easier to swallow and digest.



◀ LEOPARD SEAL

A gentoo penguin makes a desperate bid to escape the attack of a leopard seal near Cuverville Island, Antarctica.

